

The House Legacy Builds: A Formative Evaluation of the Impact of the Legacy Resident Retention Program (LRRP) on Participant Quality of Life



Glossary

Evaluation: A systematic process of collecting and analyzing data to determine effectiveness or impact of a program, and to identify areas for improvement.

Formative Evaluation: A type of evaluation focused on improving a program during its development or implementation

Data Collection

Consultant: A person who possess a deep level of knowledge on the data collection methods needed to complete an evaluation.

Thematic Analysis:

A type of qualitative data analysis that categorizes data by themes, patterns or concepts.

Quality of Life: A measure of an individual's overall well-being and satisfaction as it relates to their environment, social relationships, emotional state, and financial stability.

Overview

Between January and May 2026, five Master of Public Health students from the Rollins School of Public Health at Emory University conducted a formative program evaluation to assess the outcome of the Atlanta Beltline Partnership's Legacy Resident Retention Program (LRRP) on participant quality of life. This report outlines the evaluation team's methods, findings, and recommendations.

Introduction

The Atlanta Beltline has introduced green spaces, walkability, and increased access between Atlanta neighborhoods (Atlanta Beltline, Inc., n.d.). As a result of this development, many neighborhoods along the Beltline have experienced gentrification, rising property values, and increased property taxes.

In response to these challenges, the Atlanta Beltline Partnership created the LRRP, which aims to assist long-term homeowners living in neighborhoods surrounding the Atlanta Beltline. The LRRP has subsidized any increase in property taxes since 2019 for legacy homeowners and is currently funded through 2030.

Eligible participants must live in designated Westside and Southside neighborhoods, have purchased their home before March 2017, and have an annual household income lower than the 2025 US HUD Metro Atlanta AMI Levels (Atlanta Beltline Partnership, n.d.).

The question guiding this evaluation was:

How has the Legacy Resident Retention Program (LRRP) influenced participants' quality of life?

Methodology

A semi-structured data collection consultant interview (DCCI) was held with Ms. Tiarra Murphy, who had knowledge of the LRRP and the program evaluation. The DCCI informed data collection protocols and deepened the evaluation team's understanding of the LRRP's goals.

A quantitative survey tool provided by Ms. Tiarra Murphy was used to evaluate participant experiences with the program and its impact on their quality of life. This survey had been distributed digitally and in person to LRRP participants on two previous occasions. Ms. Tiarra Murphy also provided the team with qualitative data in the form of quotes from focus groups.

The evaluation team collected survey data in person by canvassing at homes of participants who had not yet completed the survey. Mixed-methods data analysis was conducted using focus group quotes and survey data. Our findings then informed conclusions, which were used to guide the development of data-driven recommendations.

Findings

The analyzed survey data and quotes from the focus group transcripts led our team to data-driven insights regarding the LRRP participants, and the program's influence on their quality of life. We found that participant responses fell into two main categories under “quality of life:” financial well-being and emotional well-being. Under each main category are the most important themes present in the data.

Category	Theme	Finding
Financial	Motivation for joining the LRRP	#1. Costs of Rising Property Taxes #2. Desire to Pass on Property to Future Generations #3. Fear of Losing their Home
	Need for maintenance and home repairs	61% of participants reported that the service they needed most was general maintenance, painting, and flooring. But... This can involve financial trade-offs, such as having to choose between paying for doctor visits or paying for household maintenance.
Emotional	Impact of LRRP on Stress and Worry	65% of respondents were less worried about losing their home after joining the LRRP. But... LRRP participants are experiencing increasing anxiety around the proposed 2030 end-of-funding deadline. 54% of respondents said they felt less stressed about money after joining the LRRP. But... LRRP participants are worried about being displaced and “left behind” by developers.
	Community and Outreach	LRRP participants care about the importance of strong community ties and networks, noting families, neighborhoods, and churches. Emphasizing... They value the informal networks that help with utility bills, groceries, and sharing food. Participants’ want to make others aware of the LRRP program. Emphasizing... 44% first heard about the LRRP through word of mouth. Others heard about it through flyers and the Atlanta Beltline Partnership website

“Property taxes will continue to increase. Residents who have built the community and have lived here way before the Beltline should not be at risk of losing their homes due to rising property taxes...”

“Knowing I have assistance in paying property taxes until 2030 feels like a relief. It is really helpful especially because my house is old and needs repairs, and I can afford to do them knowing how much to budget for my taxes.”

“...Before the program, I was constantly worried about how I would keep up with rising property taxes. The support from LRRP gave me peace of mind.”

“As we inch closer to 2030, I become increasingly anxious. I don’t have a realistic alternative for where to live.”

“...I appreciate this program for allowing me to maintain my dignity because ultimately I still have my home for my family.”

Conclusions:

Our findings show that the most effective component of the LRRP is supporting participants in offsetting rising property taxes. This relieves financial stress and allows people to stay in their communities, both of which enhance the quality of life of participants. Additionally, this financial support helps LRRP participants by allowing them to allocate the funds they would have used for property taxes to other necessities, which in turn also improves their overall mental and emotional health.

A potential area for improvement for the LRRP is extending financial assistance to home repairs, since many participants still struggle to afford them. Secondly, the program's 2030 expiration date raises concerns about long-term sustainability. Many participants expressed concern about the program potentially running out of funding in 2030 and the potential loss of housing. This anxiety is compounded by fears of communal displacement and loss of community ties. Currently, the LRRP does not have any community-building initiatives to counteract these concerns. Furthermore, community gatherings could increase awareness of the LRRP program and improve outreach.

Recommendations:

Below are four data-driven recommendations that could help strengthen current practices, enhance outreach, and address potential areas of improvement for the LRRP. These recommendations are listed by priority order, first in terms of urgency and then feasibility.

Priority order based on **urgency**:

1. **Extend the LRRP beyond 2030** to improve legacy resident quality of life
2. **Expand the scope of the LRRP** to assist with home repairs and maintenance
3. **Enhance outreach strategies** to recruit more LRRP participants
4. **Increase community engagement** between the Atlanta Beltline Partnership and LRRP participants and neighborhoods

Priority order based on **feasibility**:

1. **Enhance outreach strategies** to recruit more LRRP participants
2. **Increase community engagement** between the Atlanta Beltline Partnership and LRRP participants and neighborhoods
3. **Expand the scope of the LRRP** to assist with home repairs and maintenance
4. **Extend the LRRP beyond 2030** to improve legacy resident quality of life

Limitations

The data collection tools used in this program evaluation were created before the development of the evaluation question, so the questions included in the tools were not targeted to quality-of-life measures. Additionally, the survey was distributed to participants three times, and questions were added between the first and second distribution, resulting in missing data from the first group of participants. This program evaluation was also limited by a semester schedule, which affected the lengths of the data collection and data analysis periods.

Acknowledgments

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References

Atlanta Beltline, Inc. (n.d.). *History*. <https://beltline.org/about-us/history/>

Atlanta Beltline Partnership. (n.d.). *Legacy Resident Retention Program*. <https://beltline.org/live/resident-support/legacy-resident-retention-program/>